
A STRATEGIC APPROACH TO REDUCING JOB STRAIN

*A Comprehensive Step-by-Step Guideline to Tackle Increasing Job
Strain in the US and India Offices*

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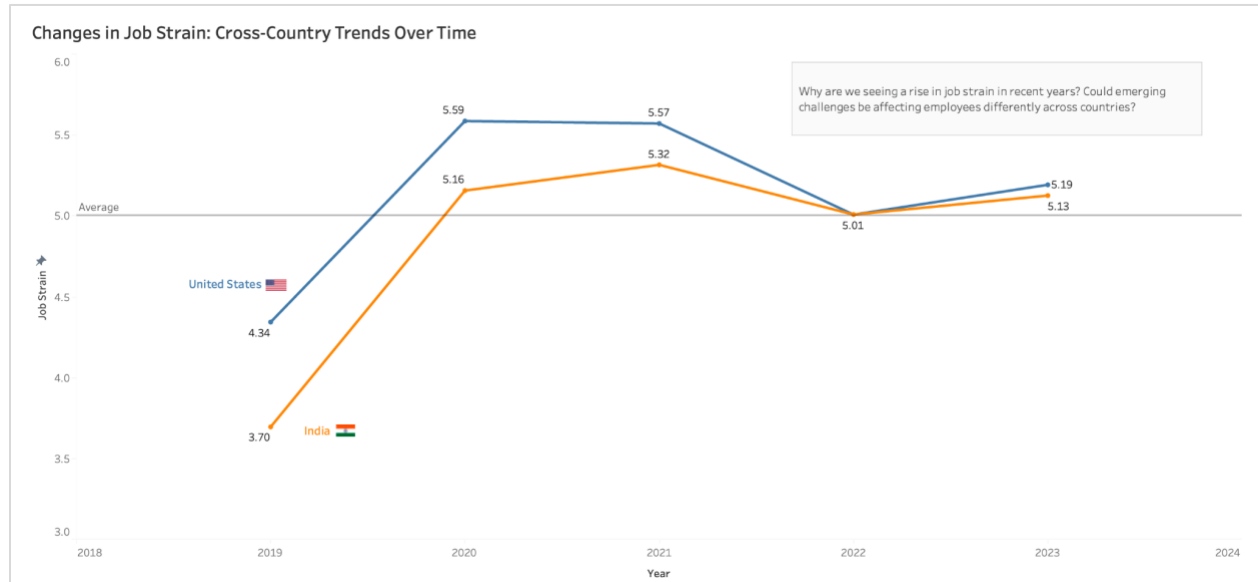
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GROUP 4

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Visuals with conclusions from each visual and associated analyses

1. Changes in Job Strain: Cross-Country Trends Over Time

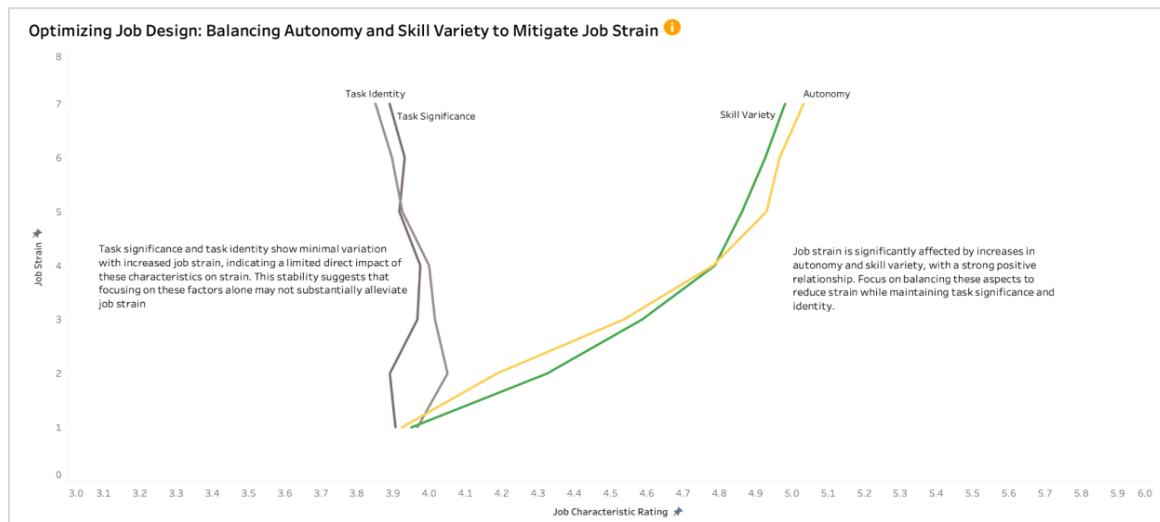


From the graph we can conclude that the job strain in both countries has been rising from 2018 to 2021. We also see that US job strain has had a higher peak compared to India.

Conclusions:

- **Rising Job Strain Over Time:** Both the United States and India experienced a steady increase in job strain from 2018 to 2021, suggesting a growing issue with workplace stress or challenges impacting employee well-being.
- **Regional changes:** The U.S. consistently shows higher levels of job strain compared to India, indicating possible regional differences in work conditions, expectations, or stressors.
- **Peak and then Decline:** After a peak in job strain in 2020 (U.S.) and 2021 (India), both countries saw a decline in 2022, aligning with the overall average. This may suggest temporary relief factors or adaptive strategies that were effective during this period.
- **Emerging Challenges:** The slight increase in job strain in 2023 hints at potential emerging challenges or stressors reappearing, proactive measures are needed to mitigate further increases.

2. Optimizing Job Design: Balancing Autonomy and Skill Variety to Mitigate Job Strain

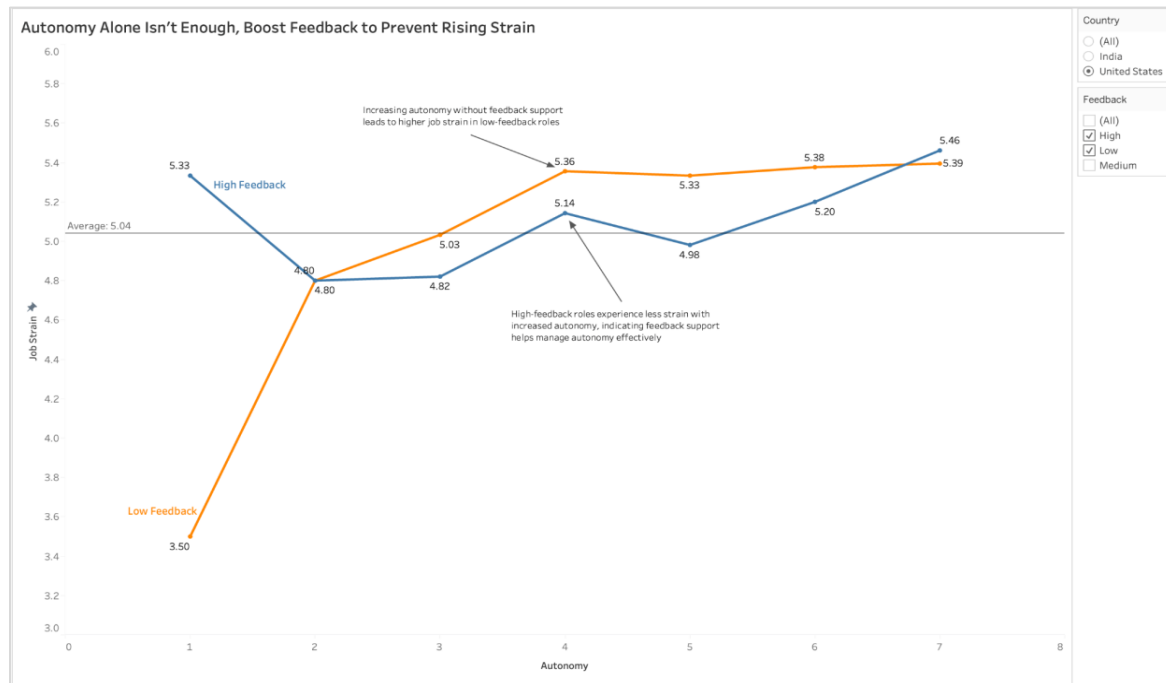


Conclusions:

- **Low impact of Task Significance and Task Identity:** The lines representing task significance and task identity show less variation across the job strain axis, indicating that these factors have a limited direct impact on job strain. This stability suggests that focusing on these aspects alone may not be effective in significantly reducing strain levels.
- **Significant Impact of Autonomy and Skill Variety:** The lines for autonomy and skill variety show a steep increase in job strain as their values rise, indicating a strong positive relationship. Higher levels of autonomy and skill variety correlate with higher job strain, suggesting these factors play a significant role in increasing strain.
- **Need for Balance:** Since both autonomy and skill variety intensify job strain, the findings imply that these factors should be balanced carefully. Simply increasing autonomy or skill variety without considering their potential to increase strain may lead to unintended negative outcomes.

Associated analysis: We conducted mediation and moderation analysis; through the observations, we could see that task significance and task identity do not have an indirect effect on job strain in any way. But skill variety and autonomy have been good mediators and moderators in several relationships that we have seen earlier. Hence, through the analysis and the graph, we can see that skill variety and autonomy do have a greater influence on job strain.

3. Autonomy Alone Isn't Enough: Boost Feedback to Prevent Rising Strain

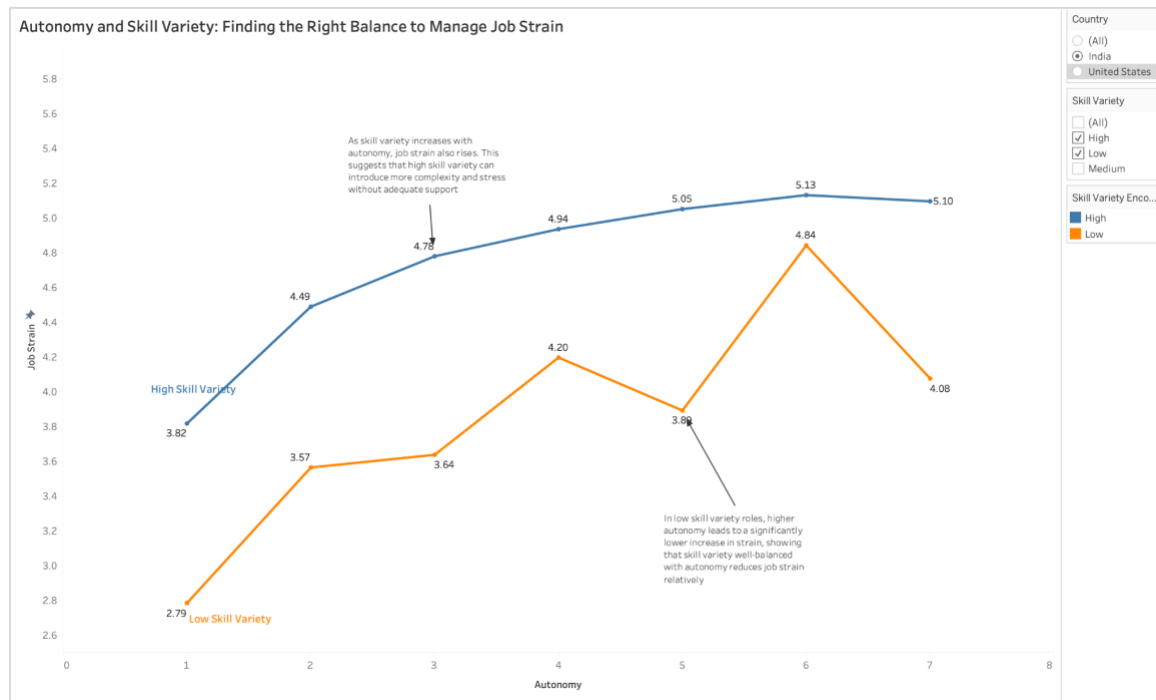


Conclusions:

- **Feedback as a Critical Moderator:** The impact of autonomy on job strain differs significantly when we add feedback to the relationship. Based on feedback levels. High-feedback roles experience relatively stable job strain even as autonomy increases, indicating that feedback helps manage the stress associated with autonomy.
- **Increased Strain with Low Feedback:** In low-feedback roles, job strain increases sharply with increased level of autonomy. This suggests that autonomy without adequate feedback support may increase the employee's stress, this shows that even employees with higher autonomy need feedback from time to time.
- **Autonomy Alone Isn't Sufficient:** Simply increasing autonomy does not necessarily reduce job strain. Feedback is essential to balance the job strain level for employees with higher levels of autonomy.
- As we see in the graph, that low feedback is reducing the job strain with less autonomy but that's an anomaly in the data.

Associated analysis: This graph comes for the moderator analysis, we see that in the relationship of autonomy and job strain "Feedback" is a strong moderator. Hence we have created this graph.

4. Autonomy and Skill Variety: Finding the Right Balance to Manage Job Strain

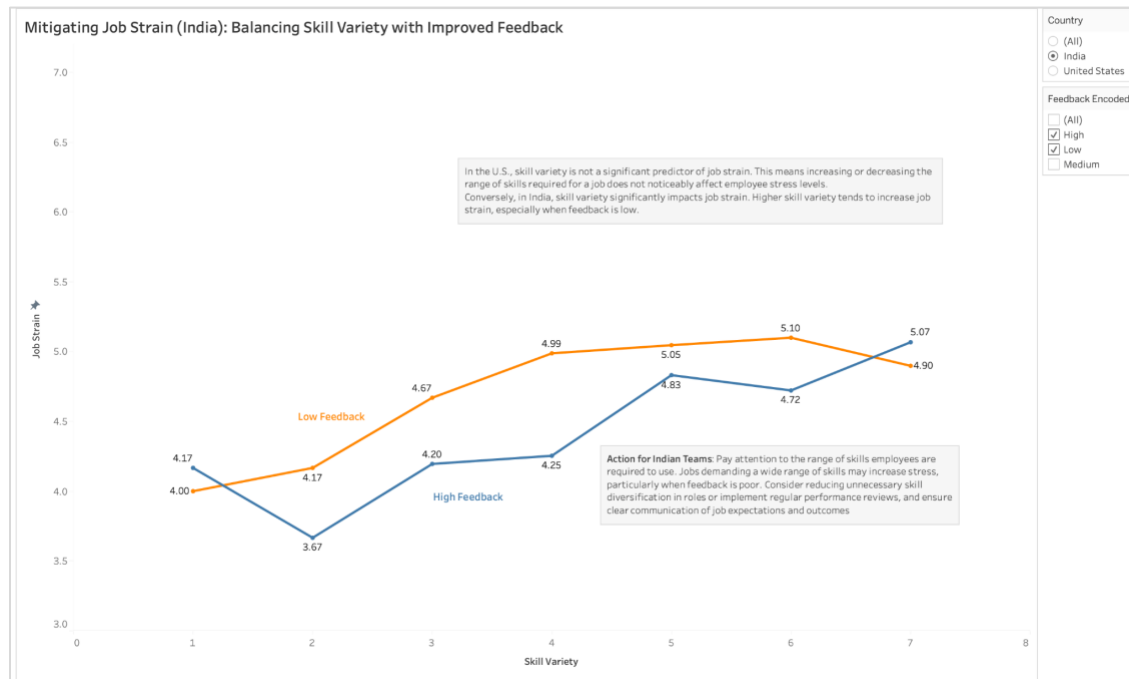


Conclusions:

- **Skill Variety as a Strain Factor:** Higher skill variety with autonomy correlates with increased job strain, indicating that while diverse skill requirements might be helpful for employees, it can also add complexity that could lead to higher stress.
- **Lower Strain with Low Skill Variety:** In low skill variety roles, higher autonomy is associated with relatively lower increases in job strain. This suggests that when skill variety is lower, employees may manage autonomy easily, possibly due to simpler or more predictable tasks.
- **Finding Balance:** The relationship between autonomy, feedback, and skill variety highlights the need to balance these characteristics to manage job strain efficiently. High autonomy should ideally be paired with either high feedback or low skill variety to minimize stress.

Associated analysis: From the analysis we have conducted till now, we identified skill variety as a strong mediator in the relationship between autonomy and job strain in both datasets. Which shows that skill variety has an indirect effect on this relationship.

5. Mitigating Job Strain: Balancing Skill Variety with Improved Feedback



Conclusions:

- High Feedback: When feedback is high, job strain remains relatively stable as skill variety increases, suggesting that adequate feedback helps employees manage the challenges of diverse skill requirements without increasing strain.
- Low Feedback: With low feedback, job strain increases significantly as skill variety rises. This indicates that without regular feedback or support, employees may feel overwhelmed by a broader range of skills, leading to higher strain.

Country differences:

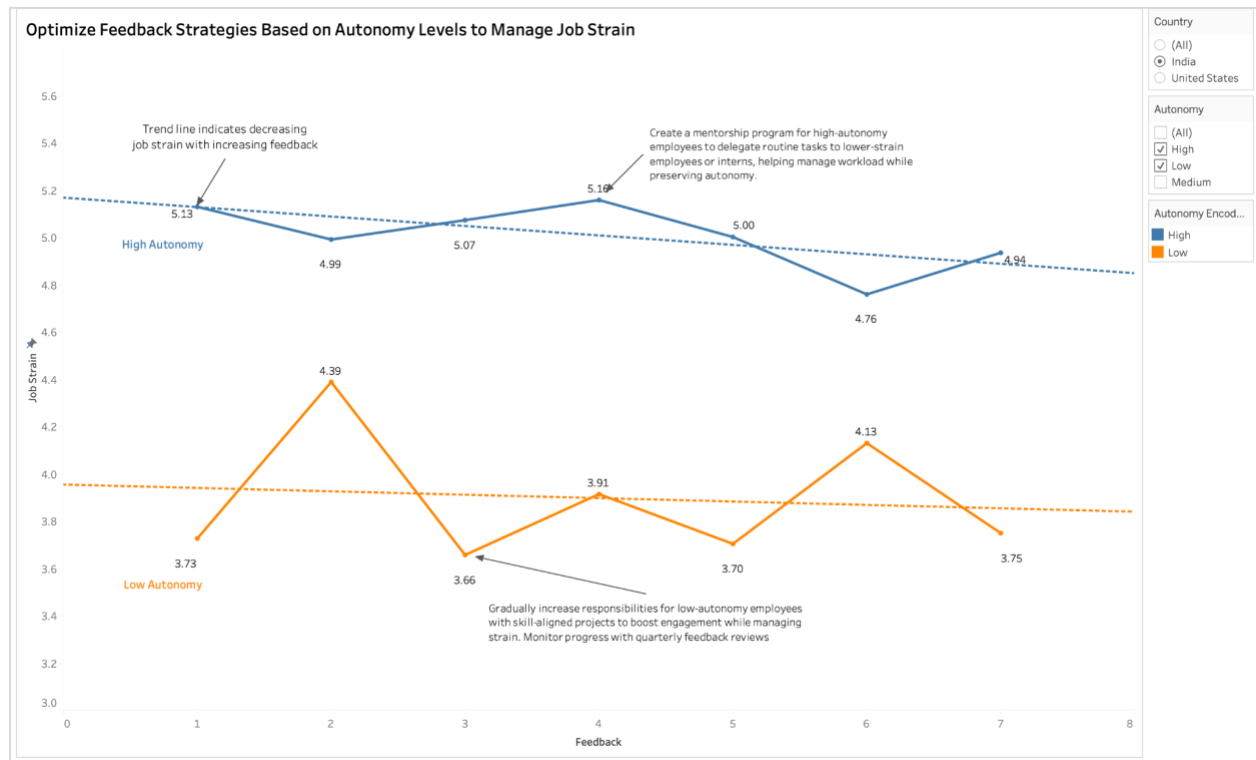
- In the U.S. dataset, skill variety does not appear to be a strong predictor of job strain, meaning that a wider or narrower range of skills does not significantly impact job strain levels. This suggests that U.S. employees may have better support or are accustomed to roles with varying skill requirements.
- In contrast, skill variety is an important factor for job strain in India, especially when feedback is low. This suggests that Indian employees may need more structured roles or support to manage the stress associated with high skill variety.

Recommendations for Indian Teams:

- To manage job strain, Indian teams should pay particular attention to jobs with high skill variety, especially where feedback is limited. Reducing unnecessary skill diversification in roles or implementing performance reviews and clear communication may help alleviate strain.

Associated analysis: In the analysis we have done earlier, in the Indian dataset Feedback was a mediator and also a moderator in the relationship between job strain and skill variety. Which explains its effect on the relationship.

6. Optimize Feedback Strategies Based on Autonomy Levels to Manage Job Strain



Feedback's Impact on High-Autonomy Roles:

- For roles with high autonomy, there is a downward trend in job strain as feedback levels increase. This indicates that increased feedback helps to reduce job strain in high-autonomy roles.
- This suggests that providing regular feedback or guidance to high-autonomy employees helps them manage the job stress associated with independent decision-making.

Stability in Low-Autonomy Roles:

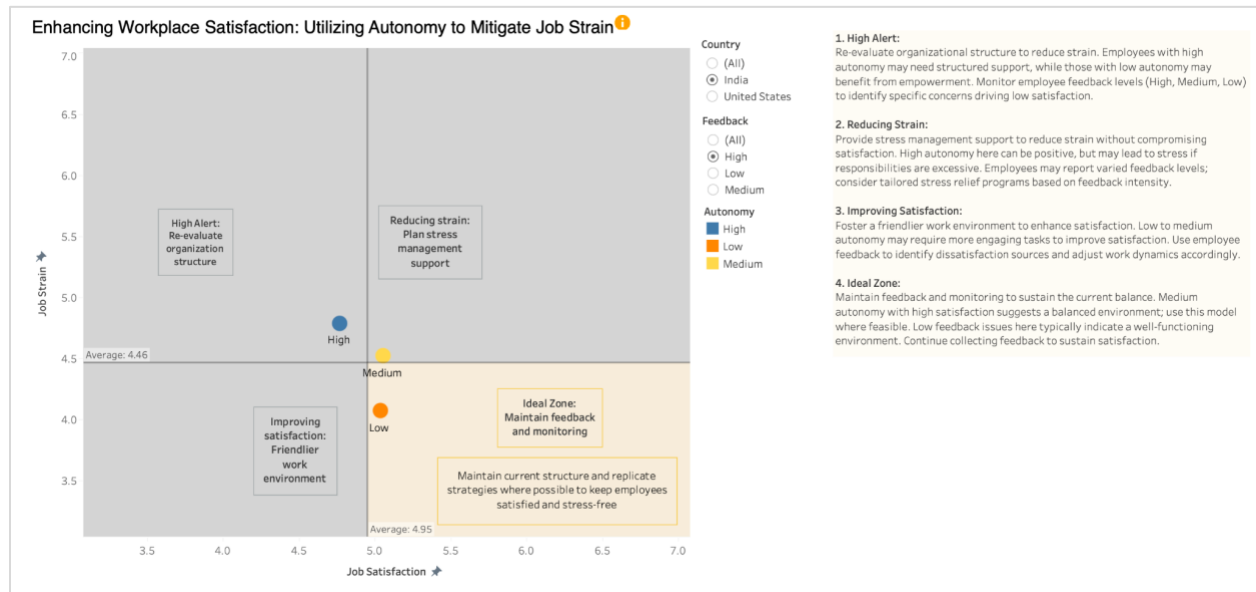
- In contrast, job strain in low-autonomy roles is relatively stable across different feedback levels, fluctuating slightly around the average job strain level of approximately 4.7.
- Low-autonomy employees experience less change in strain with different feedback levels, suggesting that feedback has a lesser impact on job strain in these roles.

Tailored Recommendations:

- For High Autonomy: A mentorship program or feedback structures that allow high-autonomy employees to delegate routine tasks can help reduce strain. This approach preserves autonomy while reducing the burden of constant decision-making.
- For Low Autonomy: Low-autonomy employees can benefit from gradually increased responsibilities or skill-aligned projects, along with consistent feedback reviews. This approach may boost engagement without adding strain.

Associated analysis: In both datasets, skill variety is the moderator. Which means that the strength of job strain and feedback's relationship is determined by skill variety.

7. Enhancing Workplace Satisfaction: Utilizing Autonomy to Mitigate Job Strain



- **High Strain with High Autonomy (Top Left - High Alert):**
 - Employees with high autonomy and low satisfaction experience the highest job strain. This suggests that high autonomy without adequate support or satisfaction can be overwhelming, potentially leading to burnout.
 - In these situations, a "High Alert" action is suggested, recommending an organizational review to add structured support for high-autonomy employees to help mitigate strain.
- **Moderate Strain with Moderate Autonomy (Top Right - Reducing Strain):**
 - For employees with moderate satisfaction and strain, structured stress management support can help to alleviate strain without compromising satisfaction.
 - Introduce tailored stress-relief programs and monitor feedback intensity. This approach helps maintain the balance between autonomy and satisfaction without overloading employees.

- Low Strain with Low to Medium Autonomy (Bottom Left - Improving Satisfaction):
 - Employees with low to medium autonomy and relatively low strain levels may benefit from a friendlier or more engaging work environment to improve satisfaction further.
 - Engage these employees with more varied or meaningful tasks to boost satisfaction. Utilizing feedback to understand dissatisfaction sources can also help enhance workplace satisfaction.
- Ideal Zone for Balance (Bottom Right - Ideal Zone):
 - This quadrant, where employees experience high satisfaction and low strain, represents the optimal balance between autonomy and feedback. Maintaining this balance can keep employees engaged, satisfied, and stress-free.
 - Continue to provide regular feedback and replicate strategies where possible to keep employees in this ideal zone, maintaining both high satisfaction and low strain.

Associated analysis: When we checked the relationship of job strain and job satisfaction, we found that autonomy is a good mediator in both datasets. That means that it has an indirect influence on the relationship between job strain and job satisfaction. Adding autonomy to this quadrant chart shows us what the level of autonomy should be ideal for lower job strain and higher job satisfaction.

Key recommendations

1. Leverage Balanced Autonomy and Feedback to Manage Job Strain: Autonomy is a powerful tool but can increase job strain if not supported by adequate feedback. To optimize job satisfaction and reduce strain, high-autonomy roles should include structured feedback systems. This ensures employees feel supported and can better manage their responsibilities, even in high-autonomy environments.
2. Tailor Feedback Intensity Based on Autonomy Levels: For high-autonomy roles, consider implementing mentorship programs and regular performance reviews. These can help employees delegate routine tasks, manage workloads effectively, and reduce strain. In low-autonomy roles, lighter feedback, focused on task-specific guidance, can help maintain engagement without overwhelming the employee.

3. **Optimize Skill Variety Based on Cultural and Regional Sensitivity:** In regions like India, high skill variety significantly impacts job strain, especially when feedback is lacking. For these teams, focus on reducing unnecessary skill diversification in roles or implementing skill-specific training. This approach can prevent strain from high skill variety while keeping employees engaged and productive.
4. **Utilize Skill Variety to Foster Engagement but Monitor for Overload:** While skill variety can enhance engagement, it may also increase job strain if poorly managed. Implement role designs that provide varied tasks aligned with employees' skill levels, but avoid excessive variety that could lead to stress. Regular feedback can help identify when skill variety is becoming a source of strain.
5. **Create a Supportive Environment in High-Job-Strain Quadrants:** In situations where both job strain and autonomy are high, organizational support, such as stress management resources or clear role definitions, can alleviate strain. Employees in this quadrant may benefit from structured support to prevent autonomy from becoming a stressor rather than an empowering factor.
6. **Foster a “Low-Strain, High-Satisfaction” Zone:** Aim to replicate the conditions of the “Ideal Zone” where employees experience high job satisfaction and low strain, typically seen in roles with moderate autonomy and consistent feedback. Use these findings to structure similar roles in other departments or regions to maintain a balanced and satisfied workforce.
7. **Focus on Building a Positive Work Environment to Enhance Satisfaction:** For roles with low to medium autonomy, satisfaction can be improved by fostering a friendlier work environment and providing meaningful, engaging tasks. Tailor the work environment and engagement efforts to boost morale, especially in lower-autonomy roles.
8. **Monitor and Adjust Based on Job Satisfaction Metrics:** Regularly assess job satisfaction and job strain metrics, especially in the high-strain and low-satisfaction quadrants, to quickly identify and address issues. Adjust feedback and autonomy levels as necessary to improve employee satisfaction and mitigate job strain across different roles and regions.